Give them a say in who they want as their candidates,' he told the AICC. In principle, it seemed like a bold innovation, designed to 'open up' the political system. In practice, it was a disaster—some sitting MPs objected to their constituencies being chosen for this, and there were familiar charges of bogus voting and infighting. 'Of all the daft things we did, this was one of the stupidest. Instead of fighting an election, we were fighting amongst ourselves,' a senior Congress leader later told me. He was right. India is not the US, and if a political experiment is to be attempted, it can't be done on the eve of a crucial national election. The primaries were held in February and March even as the campaign was kicking off. Not even one out of the fifteen candidates chosen through the primary system won their election—the naivety of Rahul's team was cruelly exposed yet again.

The 'primary' concept also exposed the widening gulf between Rahul and the old guard in the Congress. Ticket distribution in the Congress is a complex exercise aimed at faction management—the party distributes the tickets to various groups based on a traditional patron–client system. It was perhaps an archaic way of functioning, but many Congressmen felt it was the only system which worked. 'In previous elections, Ahmedbhai [Ahmed Patel, Sonia's political secretary] managed it all and we had clarity. But with Rahul, we were always second-guessing what he was planning to do next,' a senior Congressman told me. Another veteran Congressman was more caustic. 'When you fight an election, you give tickets based on "winnability"—Rahul seemed to be handing out character certificates.' Even here, there was no consistency. Ashok Chavan was given a ticket even though he hadn't recovered from the Adarsh scam taint but Suresh Kalmadi was frozen out.

A senior political commentator met Rahul in early February while he was preparing for the election campaign. He came out of the two-hour-long meeting convinced that Rahul was 'totally out of it'. 'It was just one long crib session. He kept telling me how he is just a cog in the wheel, and how difficult the UPA-II government had made life for the Congress, how he was having difficulty finding the right people for the party,' the analyst recalls. Rahul apparently even felt that 'inflation' wouldn't hurt the